

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Thyroid Disorders in Pregnancy

Thyroid hormone is essential for your baby's brain development -- with proper monitoring, most women have healthy pregnancies

WHY THE THYROID MATTERS

- The thyroid makes hormones that control **metabolism, energy, and temperature**
- Your body needs **more thyroid hormone** during pregnancy
- Your baby depends on your thyroid for **brain development**, especially in the first trimester
- Thyroid disorders affect about **2-3% of pregnancies**
- Most cases are safely managed with medication and monitoring

HYPOTHYROIDISM (UNDERACTIVE)

- **Symptoms:** fatigue, weight gain, cold intolerance, constipation, dry skin
- **Risks if untreated:** miscarriage, preeclampsia, preterm birth, low birth weight
- Treated with **levothyroxine** -- safe in pregnancy
- Most women on thyroid medication need a **dose increase** during pregnancy
- Blood tests checked every **4-6 weeks**

HYPERTHYROIDISM (OVERACTIVE)

- Most often caused by **Graves' disease**
- **Symptoms:** rapid heartbeat, weight loss, anxiety, tremors, heat intolerance
- **Risks if untreated:** miscarriage, preterm delivery, low birth weight, fetal thyroid problems
- Treated with **antithyroid medication** at the lowest effective dose
- Requires frequent blood testing

WHO NEEDS THYROID TESTING?

- ✓ Personal or **family history** of thyroid disease
- ✓ Autoimmune disorders (such as **Type 1 diabetes**)
- ✓ Prior thyroid **surgery or radiation**
- ✓ Symptoms of thyroid dysfunction
- ✓ Women on thyroid medication should be **tested early** in pregnancy

IODINE, BREASTFEEDING & POSTPARTUM

- ✓ Aim for **200-250 mcg iodine daily** from prenatal vitamins and diet
- ✓ **Do not take extra iodine** unless instructed
- ✓ **Levothyroxine** is safe while breastfeeding
- ✓ Most antithyroid medications are safe at appropriate doses
- ✓ **Postpartum thyroiditis** can occur within the first year after delivery -- follow-up labs may be needed

PLANNING PREGNANCY

- ✓ Make sure thyroid levels are **stable before conceiving**
- ✓ Contact your physician **as soon as pregnancy is confirmed**
- ✓ Early **medication adjustments** are often needed
- ✓ Continue prenatal vitamins with iodine
- ✓ Keep all scheduled lab appointments

⚠️ CALL YOUR DOCTOR IF YOU EXPERIENCE

- ⚠️ Palpitations or rapid heartbeat
- ⚠️ Severe fatigue or weakness
- ⚠️ Sudden weight loss or weight gain
- ⚠️ Swelling in the neck, hands, or face
- ⚠️ Severe headaches or elevated blood pressure
- ⚠️ Heat or cold intolerance that is new
- ⚠️ Anxiety, tremors, or mood changes
- ⚠️ Symptoms that worsen during or after pregnancy

Healthy Thyroid, Healthy Pregnancy

Thyroid disease during pregnancy sounds scary, but with regular monitoring and the right medication dose, nearly all women go on to have healthy babies. The key is early testing, consistent follow-up labs, and taking your medication exactly as prescribed. Please bring any questions about your thyroid care to your next visit -- we are here to help.